countervailing assurance through deeper ties with the United States, as well as with Japan, South Korea, Australia, and the Association for South East Asian Nations (ASEAN) states, particularly Vietnam and Indonesia. However, India's strategy towards the Indo-Pacific region is not based solely on balance-of-power politics to the exclusion of cooperation. India has never actively pursued a balancing strategy or taken part in a containment or alliance directed against China. Indeed, India hopes for the opposite: to comprehensively engage China through diplomacy, trade, and institutions. In fact, India's contestation and cooperation with China will go hand in hand. For India, the long-term goal is to create a cooperative security framework in the Indo-Pacific. Nevertheless, without continued American presence and determination to preserve a balance of power in Asia, it will not be possible to forge a cooperative security architecture in the Indo-Pacific region, at least in a short- or medium-term outlook.

Changing dynamics between the great powers within the larger Indo-Pacific lead to increased uncertainty. In the introductory chapter to this volume, the editors present a theoretical framework that includes the policy option of hedging that mixes cooperation and competition to manage uncertainty in the international environment. In this chapter, the author will show how India emphasises exactly such a mix in the quest for a stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific region.

The future of peace and stability in Asia will most likely be defined by a combination of building interdependence through institutions and economic cooperation and balancing power. Interdependence and balance of power both contribute to stability, albeit in different ways.[2] There is not enough evidence from Chinese diplomatic practice, except rhetorically, that China abnegates hegemonism and embraces the idea of multipolarity. If that were the case, there would be no impediment to the rise of China and no